

CORE FORMULA

Listen: "I want to understand this from your side. What is the part people keep missing?" -> **Empathise:** "Given that, I can see why this feels risky / insulting / exhausting." -> **Agree:** "I agree you should have a real say in what happens next." -> **Partner:** "Can we find one step that protects that and still handles the concern?" -> **Compact:** "From your side, [their view]. I can see why [feeling] is there. I agree [true point]. Would you be open to [small next step]?"

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Say "I want to understand your side before I respond - what matters most to you here?", reflect it back, name one honest thing you agree with, then ask "Would you be open to working out one next step together?"

BEST FOR

- Someone rejects advice, help, feedback, or a proposed plan
- A disagreement has become personal or identity-protective
- They say "you don't understand," "you're not listening," or "stop trying to fix me"
- The factual argument has already been made and is not landing
- You need to preserve dignity while still moving towards action
- The other person has a strong need for control, safety, respect, or status
- Family, care, management, customer, or coaching talks where trust is weak

PHRASE BANK

Listen openers · Open the door

- "I want to get your version before I respond."
- "What's the part I'm not understanding yet?"
- "Tell me what this looks like from your side."
- "What matters most to you here?"
- "I'm going to slow down and listen first."
- "Can I say your side back before I respond?"
- "What do you think people keep getting wrong?"

Empathise · Name the human logic

- "That sounds exhausting to keep defending."
- "I can see why that would feel like people aren't respecting you."
- "If I believed that was happening, I'd be guarded too."
- "It makes sense that you'd want more control here."
- "I hear how much this matters to you."
- "If it feels like people are deciding for you, I get why you'd push back."

Agree · Honest common ground

- "I agree that you should have a say in what happens next."
- "I agree that being talked over is not okay."
- "I agree that we need a plan that doesn't make this worse."
- "I agree that trust has to come before any bigger step."
- "I agree that the next step needs to feel workable, not forced."
- "I agree you should not feel managed by me."

Partner · Invite a shared step

- "Would you be willing to work out one step together?"
- "What would make this feel less like pressure and more like a choice?"
- "Can we find an option that protects your concern and handles mine?"
- "What's the smallest next step you wouldn't hate?"
- "Would you prefer option A, option B, or a different idea altogether?"
- "What would actually feel helpful rather than controlling?"

Work and meetings · Professional context

- "Before I propose anything, I want to understand the constraint you're protecting."
- "I agree any plan has to respect that constraint. Can we design around it?"
- "I can see why that would feel risky for the team."
- "It sounds like we're aligned on the timeline; can we work through the budget?"
- "Can we design around that constraint together?"
- "I'd rather understand your objection properly than argue past it."

High pressure and safety · Hold the line, keep it safe

- "I'm not here to corner you. I do need us to keep this safe."
- "I can pause the argument. I can't ignore the risk."
- "We don't have to settle the whole issue now - only the next safe step."
- "I want to respect your choice, and I also can't ignore immediate safety."
- "What's the least intrusive safe step we can both live with?"
- "I want to do this with you, not to you."

Reset mid-conversation · Soften and re-open

- "I may be missing your side. What's the main concern from where you sit?"
- "This is landing badly. I want to slow down."
- "I'm not trying to win. I want to understand why this feels so big."
- "Let me be more precise about what I actually agree with."
- "I pushed too fast. Can we reset and start with what you want protected?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "You are wrong, but I am listening."

Better: "I hear that you don't see it that way. What am I missing?"

Best: "From your side, this feels like people are deciding for you. I can see why that would make you resist. I agree you should have a say. Can we find one step that keeps your choice intact and still handles the concern?"

2. Weak: "I agree, so will you do what I asked?"

Better: "I agree the current plan feels too heavy. Could we shrink it?"

Best: "I agree the current plan asks too much at once. What's the smallest version you'd be willing to try for one week?"

3. Weak: "Calm down. I'm trying to help."

Better: "This is landing badly. I want to slow down."

Best: "I pushed too fast. I can see why that felt like pressure. I agree we shouldn't make a rushed decision. Could we reset and start with what you want protected?"

DECISION TREE

If Immediate danger or urgent safety risk

Prioritise safety, professional support, or escalation. Stay respectful, but don't rely on LEAP as the sole intervention.

"I need us to keep everyone safe first; we can talk this through properly after."

If They mainly want to be heard, not moved

Stay in Listen and Empathise; hold off on any Partner step until they settle.

"I'm not going to push anything. I just want to understand this properly."

If There's active resistance, distrust, or refusal

Run the full LEAP sequence, one step at a time.

"I want your side before I respond. What keeps getting missed?"

If You can't find an honest point of agreement

Don't fake it. Name the shared aim instead of pretending to agree.

"I may not agree yet, but I do want to understand what you want protected."

If They're not ready for a next step

Ask what would make a future conversation feel safer or more workable.

"What would make talking about this feel less like pressure?"

If The Partner step doesn't protect autonomy and safety

Shrink the step, add options, or set a clear boundary.

"What's the smallest version of this you'd actually be willing to try?"

SCENARIOS

Family refuses support

Listen for what feels humiliating or controlling; protect dignity and choice before any next step. — "I agree you should have a say. Could we choose one low-pressure next step together?"

Workplace impasse

Reflect the constraint they're protecting - competence, fairness, risk - before proposing anything. — "I agree the plan has to respect the client risk you're seeing. Can we design around it?"

Customer complaint

Empathise with the impact, agree on the service standard, then partner on the options. — "I agree this should have been clearer. Here are two ways we can make the next step easier."

Friend in a charged personal decision

Ask what they want protected, reflect it, then offer to compare the options together. — "I agree keeping your independence matters. Want to look at choices that don't take that away?"

Digital conflict

Slow the thread and reflect before solving, since text reads colder than intended. — "I think I missed your main concern. What I'm hearing is... Is that right?"

Safety-adjacent conversation

Preserve dignity while naming the safety boundary; don't let LEAP replace proper procedure. — "I want your choice involved as much as possible, and I can't ignore immediate safety. Let's pick the least intrusive safe step."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Immediate safety risk that requires emergency action
- You are using the method to hide pressure, sales intent, or coercion
- You cannot find any honest point of agreement
- You are too activated to listen without contempt
- The situation needs formal investigation, legal process, or medical judgement
- The other person has clearly withdrawn consent to keep talking

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the signal

Catch one real moment of resistance today - a correction loop, a flat refusal, a "you don't get it" - and just name it silently. No fixing, only noticing the cue.

Day 2 — One clean Listen question

In a low-stakes disagreement, ask a single open question and let the answer breathe. Don't load your rebuttal while they talk.

Day 3 — Empathise with no "but"

Take a blunt line like "you need to stop this" and write the Empathise sentence - the feeling underneath it - with no "but" attached.

Day 4 — Honest agreement reps

For "everyone's against me," "this is pointless," and "you just want control," find one true agreement each that doesn't endorse the whole claim.

Day 5 — Shrink the Partner step

Take a large demand and rewrite it as the smallest choice-based next step the person could voluntarily accept for a single week.

Day 6 — Four-line LEAP conversion

Convert one blunt statement into all four lines - Listen, Empathise, Agree, Partner - then say them aloud until they sound like you, not a script.

Day 7 — Boundary with respect

Run a full LEAP in a real conversation, adding a clear limit: "I want to respect your choice, and I also can't ignore [risk]. What's the least intrusive safe step?"

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I actually understand their view, or did I only wait to respond?
- Did I empathise with the experience without endorsing false or unsafe claims?
- Was my agreement specific, honest, and small enough to be true?
- Did the Partner step preserve real choice?
- Did I name safety boundaries clearly where they were needed?
- Did I use LEAP to build respect, not to hide pressure?